ANIMATE DEAD (5E, 2024 RULES) – DESCRIPTION

Level 3 – Necromancy
Casting Time: 1 minute · Range: 10 feet
Components: V, S, M (a drop of blood, a piece of flesh, and a pinch of bone dust) · Duration: Instantaneous
Classes: Cleric, Wizard

Choose a pile of bones or a corpse of a Medium or Small Humanoid within range. The target rises as an **Undead** (Skeleton or Zombie stat block).

On each of your turns, you can use a **Bonus Action** to mentally command any creature made by this spell if it is within 60 feet of you. You decide its action and movement for its next turn, or issue a general command. If you issue no commands, it only defends itself.

The creature is under your control for **24 hours**, after which it stops obeying. To keep control for another 24 hours, you must cast this spell on it again before the current period ends: this reasserts your control over up to four creatures you animated with this spell.

Higher-level slot: you animate or reassert control of one more creature for each slot level above 3.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. 1-minute casting on a corpse or bones.
2. The Undead rises (Skeleton or Zombie).
3. Command with a Bonus Action, within 60 ft.
4. 24 hours of control; recast to extend.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The text leaves open what an Undead does without orders other than defending itself. Fix: stick to the text (it only defends itself).

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can describe bones snapping together, a body rising, empty sockets.

Step 1 – Choose the body:

A pile of bones or a corpse of a Medium or Small Humanoid within 10 ft. 1-minute casting.

Step 2 – The Undead rises:

It uses the Skeleton or Zombie stat block.

Step 3 – Give orders:

Bonus Action on your turn to command each creature within 60 ft. Without orders: it only defends itself.

Step 4 – Extend:

Recast before the 24 hours end to keep control for another 24 hours (up to 4 creatures).

Example: Lysa (Wizard) casts Animate Dead on a skeleton. Next turn, she orders it to attack a guard. After 24 hours, she recasts the spell to keep it.

ANIMATE DEAD (5E, 2024 RULES) – Q&A AND DEBATE

⚠ Common questions:

How long does control last?
24 hours, then the spell must be recast.

What action to command?
A Bonus Action, within 60 ft.

What does it do without orders?
It only defends itself.

How many creatures can I control?
As many as the spell allows, up to 4 per recast.

What kind of body?
A corpse or pile of bones of a Medium or Small Humanoid.

Which stat block?
Skeleton or Zombie.

Does Dispel Magic destroy it?
No: the spell is instantaneous, there is nothing to dispel.

⚠ Debate points and table options:

Table rule

Control duration
The spell is instantaneous, control lasts 24 hours. **Option**: keep it; or control ends at next dawn.

General orders
A general command is followed until complete. **Option**: the DM specifies what counts as complete.

Controlling several creatures
The spell allows one shared command. **Option**: keep it.

Target size
The target is Medium or Small. **Option**: the DM specifies edge cases (hybrid creatures).

End of control
After 24 hours, the creature stops obeying. **Option**: it turns hostile; or stays inert.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Dispel and the Undead
Animate Dead is instantaneous: *Dispel Magic* and *Antimagic Field* don't affect the created creature, as no spell is ongoing.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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